Plato, Statesman 274e–293a: Text and Notes (Horan translation)

This companion volume continues an earlier study of 257a–274e. It sets David Horan's translation of the Statesman (Platonic Foundation, version of 17 May 2026) beside short notes read from an orthodox Catholic point of view. Horan's text is reproduced word for word; bracketed markers such as [275a–276a] show the Stephanus range of each page of his edition, so line-exact Stephanus positions are approximate within a page. Readings credited to Mac are his own, carried forward from the first volume. Scripture is quoted from the Douay-Rheims (Challoner), with its numbering.

274e–277a — Correcting the myth; feeding versus care; willing versus forced

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[274e–276a] But we shall now make use of it, in order to discern the extent of our error in presenting an account of the king and the statesman in the earlier discussion. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** But how do you say our error occurred, and what was the extent of it? **STRANGER:** In one sense it was more trivial, but in another sense it was extremely significant, and much greater and more extensive than I thought at the time. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** In what way? **STRANGER:** When we were asked about the king and statesman belonging to the current revolution and manner of coming into being, we described the shepherd of the human herd belonging to the opposite cycle, and he was a god rather than a mortal, and in this way we went completely wrong. However, when we presented him as ruling the entire city, we did not state the manner of such rule, and in that sense, although we did speak the truth, it was not stated comprehensively or clearly, and therefore we were in error, but to a lesser extent than that. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** True. **STRANGER:** Then once we have defined the manner of such rule over the city, we should expect accordingly to describe our statesman comprehensively. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Very good. **STRANGER:** And it was for these reasons we included the myth, in order to point out not only that when it comes to herd nurture, everyone nowadays disputes over that title with the person we are looking for, but also to discern	The Stranger admits the first account went 'completely wrong' by painting a god as shepherd of today's human herd. Note that the myth's decline is cosmic: the world turns on its own and the gods let go. Mac stressed this — it is not a moral Fall brought on by sin, and Plato has no story of guilt and redemption to match Genesis. This correction fits Mac's reading of 260c–e. Heralds and prophets hand on another's command, while the king's command is his own; yet only God's command truly begins in himself, so every human king is finally a kind of herald. Christianity resolves the split Plato leaves open: Christ is both the divine shepherd and the human king. "I am the good shepherd. The good shepherd giveth his life for his sheep" (John 10:11); "And I will set up one shepherd over them, and he shall feed them, even my servant David" (Ezekiel 34:23). Renaming the art 'caring' rather than 'nurture' picks up 261c–d, where kingly knowledge was placed over living things. The statesman does not feed bodies; he looks after a common life. In its highest form, care of living things becomes care of souls — the pastoral office the Church has always seen as the summit of rule. At 276d–e the Stranger splits care into forced (tyranny) and voluntary (true kingship). Mac's point: prophet and king both command, but only the king has worldly means to enforce. Moses says "Thus saith the Lord God of Israel: Let my people go"; Pharaoh answers "Who is the Lord, that I should hear his voice?" (Exodus 5:1–2). Pharaoh's word, backed only by force, is a parody of the creative word. Keep this in view for 293a, where the true ruler may act without our consent like a doctor — that holds only when the command rests on truth, with the prophet's word judging the king.

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more clearly, based upon the example of shepherds and cowherds, the one person whom it is appropriate, in view of his care for the nurture of humanity, to deem worthy of this title alone. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Rightly so. **STRANGER:** And yet, Socrates, I really think that this figure of the divine herdsman is even greater than that of a king, while the statesmen of the present day have natures much more like those whom they rule over, and they share in an education and nurture closer to their subjects. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Entirely so, I presume. I suppose that's true, on the whole. **STRANGER:** Yet they should be sought out anyway, neither more nor less, regardless of whether they have the former or the latter nature. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** They must. **STRANGER:** Then let's go back once more to this point. We said that the 'own-directing' skill, as applied to living creatures, exercised its care not individually but collectively, and then we referred to it immediately as 'herd-nurture'. You do remember? **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Yes. **STRANGER:** Well, somehow we went badly wrong on this topic for we utterly failed to include the statesman or to name him. Rather he escaped our naming process without our noticing. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** How? **STRANGER:** The various other herdsmen share in the nurture of their several herds, but although the statesman has no share in this process, we still applied that name, when we should have applied, to all of them, some name they had in common. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** What you say is true, if there happens to be such a name. **STRANGER:** Why wouldn't 'ministering' be somehow common to them all, since it is not defined in terms of nurture or any other particular activity? But if we had called it 'herd-minding' or 'ministration' or 'caring', which is applicable to them all, we would have been able to include the statesman and the others simultaneously, and the argument indicated that this should be so. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Correct. But in what manner would the next division be made?	

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STRANGER: Based on the same divisions as before, when we divided herd-nurture into foot-borne, un-winged, unmixed in breed, and hornless, and dividing 'herd-minding' on the same basis, **[276b–277a]** we would presumably be encompassing kingship of today, and of the age of Cronus alike, in our account. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Apparently, but I am still asking what comes next. **STRANGER:** It is obvious that if the word 'herd-minding' had been used in this context, the contention that there is no care whatsoever would never have occurred to us, which is just what happened when it was rightly contended that in the case of humans, there is no skill worthy of the title 'nurturing'. And even if there were such a skill, many people have a prior and better claim to it than any of our kings. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Correct. **STRANGER:** But when it comes to the common care of humanity in its entirety, no other skill would wish to assert a prior and better claim than kingly rule, which is the rule of all human beings. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** What you say is correct. **STRANGER:** And yet, Socrates, after all this, do we recognise that a considerable further error was made at the very end? **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Of what sort? **STRANGER:** As follows. If we really did think that there was a skill of nurturing herds of bipeds, we should not have referred to it immediately as kingship or statesmanship with such finality. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** What then? **STRANGER:** Firstly, as we are saying, we should have changed the manner of the name, orienting it towards care rather than nurture, and then made a cut in this. Indeed, it still has capacity for significant cuts. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Of what sort? **STRANGER:** A cut, I presume, whereby we could have separated the divine shepherd and the human carer apart. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Correct. **STRANGER:** And yet it was necessary to cut the caring which has been parted off into two once more.	

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YOUNG SOCRATES: Into what? **STRANGER:** Into enforced and voluntary. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Why so? **STRANGER:** Well, I think this is how we went wrong previously when, proceeding more simplistically than we should, we treated the king and the tyrant as the same, although they are quite dissimilar in themselves and in the manner of their particular rule. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** True. **STRANGER:** But now, correcting ourselves once more, should we make a twofold division of the care of humanity into enforced and voluntary, just as I said? **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Yes, certainly. **STRANGER:** And presumably the herd-minding of subjects who are forced is tyrannical, while the voluntary herd-minding of willing two-legged creatures should be called statesmanship, and we should affirm that the one who, for his part, possesses this skill and care is really a king and statesman. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Indeed, stranger, it is likely that our exposition of the statesman may have reached a conclusion. **STRANGER:** That would be excellent for us, Socrates. But it is necessary for me to share these views with you, in common, so that they are not just your views. Right now, in my view anyway, it seems we have not yet arrived at a figure of the king that is complete. Rather, just as sculptors sometimes cause delay by rushing inappropriately to make greater and more	

277a–280a — Paradigm; letters and syllables; weaving chosen as the model

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[277b–278c] numerous additions than necessary to parts of their work, so too have we, presumably with the aim of presenting a quick and high-sounding demonstration of the error in our previous process, considered it appropriate to apply elaborate examples to the king, and drawing upon a wondrous chunk of the myth, we were compelled to employ a greater part of it than was necessary. Therefore, we have made the exposition longer, and have failed to bring a conclusion to the story fully. Indeed, our account, just like a sketch of a living creature, has a fairly adequate outline, but has not yet been given actuality as it were, from pigments and the blending of colours. But for those who are able to	The Stranger says the portrait so far is like a sculpture rushed and overdone, and turns to 'paradigm': a small, clear case that helps us see a large, obscure one. Children learning letters recognise them in short syllables first and then in harder ones. It is a humble method — learning by likeness, not by grand theory. Catholic thought loves this move. Our Lord teaches in parables, and Aquinas holds that we come to know higher things through what is known by the senses (paraphrased; see Summa Theologiae I, q. 1, a. 9). Plato's paradigm is a natural cousin of the analogy by which we speak of God from creatures.

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follow, it is more fitting to reveal every living creature through speech and argument, rather than through drawing and all sorts of craftsmanship. But for everyone else, we should resort to craftsmanship. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** That is correct. But please reveal the way in which, according to you, we have not yet described this adequately. **STRANGER:** It is difficult, my divine friend, to present anything of significance in an adequate manner without recourse to exemplars. For it is likely that each of us knows all that we know as though in a dream, and then again, when we really are awake, are ignorant of everything. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** What do you mean by that? **STRANGER:** Yes. In a strange way I seem at the moment to have raised the issue of the experience of knowledge within us. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** In what way? **STRANGER:** Blessed man, my example itself stands in turn in need of an example. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Why so? Speak, and do not hesitate on my account. **STRANGER:** Speak I must, since you are ready to follow. We know, I presume, that children, whenever they are first developing their skill in writing… **YOUNG SOCRATES:** What do we know? **STRANGER:** That they adequately recognise each of the letters in the shortest and easiest syllables, and become capable of speaking the truth in relation to those. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Of course. **STRANGER:** And yet they are doubtful about the very same letters in other syllables, and their opinions and formulations are false. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Yes, certainly. **STRANGER:** Now wouldn’t the easiest and best way to lead them on to what they do not yet recognise be as follows? **YOUNG SOCRATES:** How is it done? **STRANGER:** Firstly, to take them back to those instances in which their opinions on these same letters were correct, and having done so, then place these alongside the ones they do not yet recognise, and by comparing them, point out that there is the same common feature and characteristic present in both	Weaving is chosen as the paradigm for statesmanship. It is a homely craft — the work of the household — and that is part of the point: rule is closer to making a cloak than to herding a god′s flock.

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intertwinings, until such time as all the cases where their opinions are true have been shown, alongside all of those they don't know about. Accordingly, these act as examples that make them, in the case of all letters in all the syllables, refer to each as different insofar as it is different from the others, and as the same insofar as it is always the same as itself in the same respect. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Entirely so. **STRANGER:** So, have we fully appreciated that example has its origin when something that is the same is appreciated correctly in a different, separate context, and the two contexts, by being brought together, a single true opinion about each instance and both instances together is attained? **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Apparently so. **[278d–280a] STRANGER:** Well, would we be surprised if our soul, by nature, underwent this same process in relation to the letters of the universe, sometimes standing in a true relation to each one in a particular case, then again all at sea about all of them under different circumstances, somehow or other recognising some of the combinations correctly. But once these are transposed to the lengthy and difficult syllables of human affairs, it is ignorant once more of these same letters. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** That would be nothing particularly surprising. **STRANGER:** How could anyone, my friend, who begins from false opinion, arrive at even a small portion of truth and acquire understanding? **YOUNG SOCRATES:** That is well-nigh impossible. **STRANGER:** Well, if that's how things naturally operate, you and I would not go much astray if, having first attempted to discern the nature of example as a whole, we were to discern it in turn in a further minor example, and transposing these processes thereafter to the very important matter of the king, we were to apply the same format and proceed from the lesser. Thereafter, we should endeavour, through an example, by means of a skill, to understand the ministration towards those who live in a city so that it becomes a waking reality for us and no mere dream. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** That is surely correct. **STRANGER:** Then we should take up that earlier argument once more, that since thousands dispute with the kingly class over the care of the city, it is necessary to separate off all these competitors and leave that single personage. And we said that, to this end, we do indeed need an example.	

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YOUNG SOCRATES: Very much so. **STRANGER:** Then, what example, an insignificant one, involving the same activity as the statesman, might someone set beside it and discover what we are seeking well enough? By Zeus, Socrates, do you want, if we have nothing to hand, at least to choose weaving? And if you agree, not all of it? In fact, the weaving of items made of wool will probably suffice. Indeed, if we select it, this part of it is likely to provide the evidence we desire. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Yes, why not? **STRANGER:** Then why not do just what we did before when we divided each object by cutting parts into parts. Let's do the same thing now in relation to weaving, and as best we can go over everything again as briefly as possible, and arrive at what is useful to us now. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** What do you mean? **STRANGER:** I shall make the exposition itself my answer to you. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Excellent. **STRANGER:** Well, in the case of everything we produce or acquire, some are for the purpose of doing something, while others are a defence against suffering something. Now, some of the defences are antidotes, whether divine or human, while others are barriers. And some of the barriers are military armaments, while others are screens. And some of the screens are covers, while others are protections against heat and cold. And some of the protections are shelters, others are blankets. And some of the blankets are carpets, while a different sort are garments. And some of the garments are cut from one piece, while a different sort are put together. And some of the put-together garments are sewn, while others are put together without sewing. And some of those that are unsewn are made from the fibres of plants from the earth, others from hair. And some of those made from hair are held together by water or earth, while others bind themselves together by themselves. Now, we give the name clothes to those blankets and defences produced from materials bound together by themselves, while the skill that is particularly concerned with clothes – in the exact same way that we once said statesmanship is concerned with the city – should we now refer to this as	

280a–282c — Weaving defined; protective arts; carding and spinning

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[280b–281b] ‘clothes-making’, naming it after the activity itself? And should we also state that weaving, insofar as it is for the most part the production of clothes, differs in nothing but name from that skill in clothes-making, just as in the other consideration kingship did not differ from statesmanship? **YOUNG SOCRATES:** You are absolutely right about that anyway. **STRANGER:** Yet we should recognise after this, that once the weaving of garments has been described in this way, someone might presume that it has been adequately described because he is unable to understand that although it has been distinguished from numerous other kindred skills, it has not yet been separated from its closest collaborators. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** What sort of kindred skills do you mean? **STRANGER:** It appears you did not follow what was said, so it seems we must go back once more and begin where we ended. Yes. If you understand me, we have already cut off its closest relations by separating the assembly of blankets into those that are wrapped around and those that are placed beneath. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** I understand. **STRANGER:** And, indeed, we set aside all manufacturing out of flax or rushes and out of everything we described summarily just now as plant fibres. And furthermore, we set aside felt-making and the putting together that employs stitching and sewing, the most significant of which is shoe-making. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Entirely so. **STRANGER:** And what’s more, leather-working ministers to blankets of one piece, and all those activities concerned with shelters, and any that are involved in house-building, in carpentry as a whole, and in other skills that protect against the influx of water. All these we set aside. Also, any skills concerned with shelters, and which provide preventive products against theft and violent actions, and involve the making of lids and the fitting of doors, and are designated as parts of the skill of joinery. We also cut away the making of armaments, which was a significant and extensive division of the barrier-making power. And, indeed, at the very outset we separated off the entire skill of magic that is concerned with antidotes. And we are left with what we take to be a defence against cold weather, the very skill we were looking for, the one that manufactures a woollen barrier and has been given the name weaving.	The Stranger divides out weaving from all the protective and covering arts until it stands alone. The patience of the method is itself a lesson: right judgement about rule comes from careful distinctions, not slogans. This fills out Mac′s reading of 261b, that the king′s command is meant to bring something good into being, like God′s ″Be light made. And light was made″ (Genesis 1:3). But the weaver does not create the threads. The king′s work is to bind threads he did not make into one fabric — a creature′s share in making, not making from nothing. Carding separates; weaving joins. The statesman will need both: discerning what differs, then knitting it together. That double task — distinguishing in order to unite — is a fair summary of Christian prudence in public life.

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YOUNG SOCRATES: Yes, that's how it seems. **STRANGER:** But, my boy, having said all this, it is still not complete, for the process involved at the start of the manufacture of clothing appears to do the opposite of weaving. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** How so? **STRANGER:** The process of weaving is presumably a kind of intertwining. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Yes. **STRANGER:** And yet there is an initial process of breaking apart materials that have been combined and forced together. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** What sort of process do you mean? **STRANGER:** The process associated with the skill of the carder of wool. Or shall we dare to refer to carding as weaving, or to the carder as though he were a weaver? **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Not at all. **STRANGER:** And, indeed, if anyone refers to the production of the warp and the woof as weaving, he is assigning a name that is both bizarre and false. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** He is, indeed. **STRANGER:** What about this? Should we propose the entire skill of the fuller, and that of clothesmending, are not in any sense either the care of clothes or attention to them, or shall we also refer to these as weaving skills? **[281c–282c] YOUNG SOCRATES:** Not at all. **STRANGER:** And yet, these will all dispute with the power of the weaving skill about the attention to, and the production of, clothes, conceding the largest part to that power, while allocating important parts to themselves too. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Entirely so. **STRANGER:** Then, in addition to these claimants, it seems necessary that the skills that produce the instruments whereby the processes of weaving are accomplished will also pretend to be at least contributory causes of everything that is woven. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Absolutely correct. **STRANGER:** Now, will our account dealing with the part of weaving we have selected be definite enough, provided we position the skill as "the noblest and greatest of all those that are concerned with the care of woollen clothes"? Or	

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would we be stating something true, but neither clear nor complete until we have also taken away all those skills that surround it? **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Correct. **STRANGER:** So, shouldn't we go on to do what we are saying so that our account may proceed in due order? **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Of course. **STRANGER:** Then we should first look at two skills that are involved in all activities. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** What are they? **STRANGER:** The contributory cause of the production, and also the cause itself. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** How so? **STRANGER:** Contributory causes are those which do not produce the product itself, but provide instruments to those who do produce it, without which the activity allotted to each of the skills would never take place. However, those that bring the product itself into existence are causes. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Well, that makes sense anyway. **STRANGER:** So after this, should we refer to all that is concerned with spindles, shuttles and any other instruments that are involved in the production of garments as contributory causes, and those that minister to and produce the garments themselves as causes? **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Quite right. **STRANGER:** Now, in the realm of causes, since the skill of adorning is so extensive, it is probably best to include clothes-cleaning, clothes-mending and any ministration associated therewith as part of this, and assign all of it the name 'the skill of the fuller'. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Very well. **STRANGER:** And, indeed, carding and spinning, and everything which for its part concerns the manufacture of the clothing itself, the parts of which we are describing, is a single skill, one whose name is familiar to everyone – wool-working. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Of course. **STRANGER:** Now there are two divisions of wool-working, and each of these is,	

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at the same time, part of two skills. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** How so? **STRANGER:** Carding, and one half of the activity associated with the shuttle, and any processes that separate compounded things from one another – all these can presumably be said to belong, as one, to wool-working itself. And we said that there are two particular major skills applicable to everything, combination and separation. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Yes. **STRANGER:** Well, carding and all the activities we mentioned just now are parts of the skill of separating, for the separation into woof and warp, arising in one way by means of the shuttle,	

282d–284c — Warp and weft; contributory versus causal arts; two kinds of measure begin

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[282d–283c] and in another way by means of the hand, has acquired as many names as we mentioned a moment ago. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Entirely so. **STRANGER:** Then again, we should once more take a part of the skill of combining, a part that is at the same time a part of wool-working. Let's set aside the entire skill of dividing we find there, and cut wool-working into two parts, separative and combinative. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Let the division be made. **STRANGER:** Then, Socrates, you should go on to divide the part that at once involves combination and wool-working if we are going to properly apprehend the aforementioned skill of weaving. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** So that's what's needed. **STRANGER:** It is needed. So, let's say that one part of it is twisting while the other is intertwining. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Do I understand you? You seem to be referring to the process involved in the production of the warp as twisting. **STRANGER:** Not only of the warp, but of the woof too. Or shall we expect to find some origin for the woof that avoids twisting? **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Not at all.	The Stranger distinguishes arts that are causes of the work from those that only contribute to it (making the tools, preparing the wool). This sets up the later sorting of the many crafts in a city that serve rule without being rule. Warp and weft: the firm, tightly-spun warp and the softer weft. Later in the dialogue these become the courageous and the moderate temperaments the king must weave together. Unity here is not sameness; it is fitting different strengths to one another. Here the Stranger turns to measure: is this long discussion too long? He distinguishes measuring things against each other (greater and less) from measuring them against what is fitting. Mac read the earlier Theodorus jab about proportion (257a–b) as hinting that virtue cannot be measured; this section begins to answer him.

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STRANGER: Then you should also distinguish each of these two, for perhaps the distinction may prove opportune for you. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** In what way? **STRANGER:** As follows. Are the products of the carding process, once they have been lengthened and have also acquired breadth, referred to as drawn wool? **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Yes. **STRANGER:** Well, any of this that has been twisted by the spindle and has become hard yarn, you call warp yarn, and the skill that directs this, warp-spinning. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Correct. **STRANGER:** While any threads that for their part undergo a loose twisting and possess a measure of softness appropriate to being woven into the warp – in view of the force applied in the dressing of the cloth – these we call woof yarn, and the skill that presides over them we call woof-spinning. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Quite right. **STRANGER:** And so, the part of weaving which we have been pursuing is presumably evident to everyone by now. For whenever the combinative part that is involved in wool-working produces a web by directly intertwining woof and warp, the entire web is referred to as a woollen garment, and the skill set over it as weaving. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Quite right. **STRANGER:** So be it. Now, why ever did we not reply straight away that weaving was the twining of woof and warp, instead of going around in a circle, pointlessly making a whole range of distinctions? **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Well, stranger, nothing that was said seemed pointless to me, anyway. **STRANGER:** That is no surprise, bless you, but perhaps in time it may seem so. Well, to counteract such a malady as this, in case it ever afflicts you in future – which would be no surprise – listen to an argument which it is appropriate to state concerning everything like this. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Please state it. **STRANGER:** Well, in the first place, let's look at all excess and deficiency so that we attribute praise and blame on a reasonable basis, on occasions when the speeches involved in discussions of this sort are longer than necessary, or the	

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opposite. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** That's what's needed. 283b [283d–284c] **STRANGER:** Well, if our discussion was about these issues themselves, I think it would be proceeding correctly. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** About what issues? **STRANGER:** About length and brevity and all excess and deficiency, for I presume that the skill of measurement is concerned with all these? **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Yes. **STRANGER:** Then we should distinguish two parts of this, since that's what is necessary for our present objective. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Please tell us how to make the division. **STRANGER:** As follows. One corresponds to the shared interrelationship of greatness and smallness, and the other corresponds to the being necessary for becoming. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** What do you mean? **STRANGER:** Well, don't you think it is natural that the greater should be referred to as greater than nothing else except the lesser, and the lesser for its part as lesser than nothing other than the greater? **YOUNG SOCRATES:** I do. **STRANGER:** What about this? Won't we say also that exceeding the nature of the measure, and being exceeded by it, be it in word or deed, does actually happen. And this is how those who are good and those who are bad among us are chiefly distinguished? **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Apparently so. **STRANGER:** So, we should propose then that things can be, and can be judged to be, great and small in these two ways. But we should not state, as we did a moment ago, that they only relate to one another. Rather, as we are now saying, we should declare that they relate to one another, but also to the measure. Would you like to understand why we should say so? **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Of course. **STRANGER:** If we allow the nature of the greater to relate to nothing except to the lesser, it will never relate to the measure. Is this so? **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Quite so.	

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STRANGER: In that case, won't we destroy both the skills themselves and their products in their entirety by this argument, and what's more, obliterate the statesmanship we are now seeking and the weaving we have been describing? For all such skills are, somehow, vigilant about excess and deficiency of the measure, regarding it not as something that is not, but as something that is a difficult aspect of their activities, and indeed by so doing they preserve the measure and make everything good and beautiful. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Of course. **STRANGER:** And if we should obliterate statesmanship, our subsequent search for the knowledge of kingship will be blocked. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Very much so. **STRANGER:** Then, just as in considering the sophist we compelled what is not to be when the argument got away from us on this issue, so too mustn't we now compel the more and the less, for their part, to come to be measured not only in relation to one another, but also in relation to the source of the measure? Indeed, unless this has been agreed, it is not actually possible that a statesman, or anyone else with knowledge of practical matters, should come into being in an undisputed manner. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** In that case, as best we can, we must do the same thing now. **STRANGER:** This topic, Socrates, is more extensive than that earlier one, and you do remember how long that was. However, it is most appropriate to put forward the following hypothesis about them.	

284d–285e — Due measure (283e–284e); the arts depend on it

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[284d–285e] **YOUNG SOCRATES:** What is it? **STRANGER:** That what has been said now will be needed some time for the demonstration of the utmost precision. But for our present purposes, what is being demonstrated beautifully and adequately seems to be supported magnificently by this argument of ours, according to which we should think that all the skills exist in like manner, and at the same time, that greater and less are to be measured not only in relation to one another, but also in relation to the source of the measure. For if this measure exists, then those skills exist, and if they exist, then this also exists, and if either of these doesn't exist, neither will	Due measure completes the Theodorus jab Mac noticed. Virtue cannot be measured by comparison — one man is not virtuous by being 'more than' another — but it can be measured against the fitting, the right amount at the right time. So Mac's instinct and Plato's answer agree: virtue is not a quantity, yet it has a standard. This is close to Aquinas's teaching that the mean of moral virtue is fixed by right reason, not by arithmetic (paraphrased; Summa Theologiae I–II, q. 64, aa. 1–2). Scripture praises the Creator in the same spirit: God ordered all things in measure, number and weight (Wisdom 11:21 — cited, not quoted, as the DR text could not be retrieved).

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ever exist. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** That's right. But what comes after this? **STRANGER:** Obviously we would divide the skill of measurement in the manner stated, cutting it into two, and designating one part of it as all those skills that measure number, length, depth, breadth, and speed in relation to their opposites. While the other one measures them in relation to the measure, to what is appropriate, timely, necessary, and whatever else betakes itself away from the extremes towards the mean. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Yes. Each of the divisions you describe is significant, and very different from one another. **STRANGER:** Yes, Socrates. Many refined thinkers, believing themselves to be stating something wise, declare that measurement is concerned with everything that comes into being, and this is just what we are saying. For, in a sense, everything that involves a skill partakes of measurement. And yet, because people are unaccustomed to investigation by dividing on the basis of forms, they immediately combine these together as the same, despite their degree of difference, since they regard them as similar. And they also do the opposite of this, separating what is different, but not on the basis of its parts. What is necessary is that when someone first perceives what is common to many, he should not desist until he beholds therein all the differences that repose within their forms. On the other hand, when he beholds the variety of dissimilarities in multiplicities, he must be incapable of getting disconcerted and stopping until, having brought all the kindred into one particular class of likeness, he encompasses them in being. Now, let these statements concerning these matters suffice, and also those concerning deficiencies and excesses. However, let's just note carefully that two kinds of measurement concerning these have been discovered, and let us remember what we say they are. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** We shall remember. **STRANGER:** Well, after this account we should entertain another consideration concerning the very things we are seeking, and concerning all conduct of discussions of this sort. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** What is it? **STRANGER:** Suppose someone were to ask us about students learning their letters. Whenever one of them is asked what letters make up a particular word, would we say that the query is presented to him on that occasion more for the	The Stranger says all the arts stand or fall with this kind of measure. Every good craft, and so every good ruler, looks to what the thing ought to be, not merely to what rivals are doing.

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sake of the word, the one he is presented with, or for the sake of his becoming more skilled in all words he comes across? **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Obviously it is for the sake of becoming skilled in all of them. **STRANGER:** And what about our present enquiry concerning the statesman? Has it been posed more for the sake of this person himself or for the sake of becoming more skilled in dialectic concerning everything? **YOUNG SOCRATES:** In this case too, it is obviously for the sake of everything. **STRANGER:** Yes. I presume that no one in his right mind would wish to pursue this account of weaving for the sake of the subject itself. But I think most people overlook the fact that readily comprehensible, perceptible likenesses are naturally present for some of the things that are, and it is not at all difficult to present these when one wishes to give an easy demonstration	

286a–287b — Why the long way round; the length of the discussion (286d)

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[286a–287b] to someone who asks for an account thereof which is uncomplicated and non-verbal. However, in the case of the most significant and revered of the things that are, there is no image at all wrought in clear view before humanity, by pointing to which someone who wishes to satisfy the soul of an enquirer may do so in an adequate manner by fitting it to some aspect of our sense perceptions. Therefore, it is necessary to practise being able to give and to receive an account of each. For the things that are devoid of body, being the most beautiful and the most significant, are shown clearly by the argument alone, and by nothing else, and all that we are now saying is said for the sake of those. But it is easier to practise anything on lesser matters rather than greater ones. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** You have expressed that perfectly. **STRANGER:** Then let us recall the reasons why we have had so much to say about all this. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** What were they? **STRANGER:** Not least was the aversion we felt over the lengthy account which dealt with weaving, and over the reverse-motion of the universe, and, in the case of the sophist, the being of non-being when we realised how very lengthy it was. And we rebuked ourselves over all of this, fearing that we might be stating something over-elaborate as well as lengthy. So we should declare that	At 286d the Stranger defends long discussions: they are judged not by pleasure or speed but by whether they make us better at dialectic and at finding the truth. Due measure applies to talk too. This is a gentle rebuke to impatience, and a useful one for any reader of Plato. The aim of the exercise is formation, not just the conclusion — much as the Church's lectio is about being shaped by the text, not finishing it.

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everything we have said so far was on account of these concerns, so that nothing of this sort should happen to us again. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Be it so. Just say what comes next. **STRANGER:** Well, I say that it is necessary for you and me, remembering what has just been said, to allocate censure and praise on each occasion for the brevity and, at the same time, the length involved in the expositions we so often deliver by judging their length not in relation to one another, but on the basis of the part of the skill of measuring that we said we should remember – namely, in relation to what is appropriate. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Rightly so. **STRANGER:** Yes. But this is not applicable in all cases, for we shall not have need of length which is added on for the sake of pleasure, except as a secondary consideration. And again, in relation to the enquiry into the issue before us, the argument directs us to favour the easiest and quickest approach as something we should seek out as a second priority, not as a first. First and foremost, we should respect the method itself, by which we are able to make divisions on the basis of forms. And, indeed, should a discussion prove inordinately lengthy, and yet place the hearer in a better position to make discoveries, we should take it seriously and be untroubled by its duration. And the same applies if it is very short. Furthermore, besides these considerations, someone who criticises gatherings of this sort, due to the length of the discussions, and finds the circular course of the arguments hard to accept, should not be allowed to turn and go on the spot, in all haste, having levelled his criticism solely on the basis of the length of what was said. No, he should also prove that we should accept that the people present would have been rendered more skilled in dialectic – and better at discovering the exposition of things that are – by an account, had the process been made shorter. As for the other criticisms and praises based on other criteria, we should not think about them, or even seem to hear such arguments at all. Anyway, that's enough on these issues, provided you agree with me on this. So we should go back to the statesman and apply to him the example of weaving as described before. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** That is well expressed, and we should do as you say. **STRANGER:** Now, the king has at least been separated from the many skills that are kindred, or rather from all of those that are concerned with herds. What remains, we say, are the contributory causes, and the causes applicable to the city itself. And these we should first separate from one another.	

287b–289d — The seven contributory arts

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[287c–288c] **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Correct. **STRANGER:** Now, do you realise that it is difficult to cut these in two? The reason, I believe, will become evident anyway as we proceed. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** In that case, we should do as you say. **STRANGER:** Then let's divide it at its limbs, like a sacrificial animal. And since we are unable to make a division into two, it is necessary always to cut it into a number that is as close to two as possible. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** But how should we do so in this case? **STRANGER:** Just as we did before, when we designated all the skills that provide tools related to weaving as contributory causes. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Yes. **STRANGER:** And now we should do the same thing, but more extensively than before. Indeed, whatever skills produce any significant or insignificant tools for the city should all be designated as contributory causes, for, without these, neither city nor statesmanship would ever come into existence. Yet, on the other hand, I presume we shall not designate any of these as belonging to the work of the skill of kingship. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** No, indeed. **STRANGER:** And, indeed, we are undertaking a difficult task in separating this class from the others. For it is possible for someone to maintain that anything whatsoever is an instrument of something or other, and seem to be making a persuasive case. Nevertheless, we should mention a particular one of the city's possessions that is different. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** In what sense? **STRANGER:** Insofar as it does not possess this ability to act as an instrument. For it is not constructed to act as a cause of some production, as is the case with an instrument, but constructed in order to preserve what has been produced. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** What sort of thing is this? **STRANGER:** Well, this is a variegated object, wrought for dry goods, for liquids, for use on the fire and for general use. We call it by a single name, 'vessel', and this very commonplace object does not, in my view, belong at all to the knowledge we are looking for anyway.	The Stranger lists the arts that supply the city: raw materials, tools, vessels, vehicles, defences, amusements, and nourishment. None of these is statesmanship, though each is needed. The list honours ordinary work. Catholic social teaching makes the same point: the farmer, the potter and the craftsman share in the common good, and their labour has dignity, though it is not the same as governing. Notice the patience again: the king is found by sorting what he is not. A ruler who thinks he must do everything has forgotten that his task is to order the work of others, not to replace it.

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YOUNG SOCRATES: No, how could it? **STRANGER:** Well, we should also take note of a third extensive object, different from these possessions of the city. It goes by land and by water, it wanders a lot and does not wander, it is worthy of reverence and unworthy of reverence. And yet it bears a single name, because all are intended for sitting upon, and always act as a seat for someone. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** What is it? **STRANGER:** I presume we call it a carriage, so it is not really the work of statesmanship, but much more of carpentry, pottery-making and bronze-working. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** I understand. **STRANGER:** What about a fourth? Should we say that there is something different from those three, one that includes most of what we mentioned some time ago – all sorts of clothing, most armaments, walls, and all enclosures whether of earth or of stone, and myriads of others? Since all these are produced for defensive purposes, it would be most appropriate to refer to them as a whole as a barrier, and to regard this more correctly as belonging much more to the work of the builder's skill or to weaving, for the most part, rather than statesmanship. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Yes, certainly. **STRANGER:** And as a fifth, would we like to suggest adornment and painting and whatever imitations are effected through their use, and through music, which having been produced solely for our pleasure are quite rightly captured by a single name? **[288d–289d] YOUNG SOCRATES:** What is it? **STRANGER:** We do use the term 'plaything', I presume. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Of course. **STRANGER:** Well, it will be appropriate to assign this one name to them all, for none of them has any serious purpose. Rather, they are all done for the sake of amusement. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** That too is something I understand fairly well. **STRANGER:** And that which provides all these with the materials from which, and in which, any of the skills mentioned just now do their work – a variegated sort that owes its origin to many different skills – shall we designate this as a	

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sixth? **YOUNG SOCRATES:** What sort of thing are you referring to? **STRANGER:** Gold and silver and anything whatsoever that is mined; and whatever all felling and lopping of trees provides to carpentry and basket-weaving, through the cutting process; and again, the stripping of bark from trees; and leather-working which strips the skins from the bodies of ensouled creatures, and any skills related thereto; and the ability to produce cork and papyrus and ropes. All these enable the manufacture of compounded forms from classes that are not compounded. Let's refer to it all as one, the primeval acquisition of humanity, uncompounded too, and in no way the work of kingly knowledge. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Very well. **STRANGER:** Then the acquisition of nutriment and whatever mixes into the body, and mixing parts of itself with parts of the body has some power to promote its health, should be called the seventh. And we should give the name 'nurture' to the totality, if we don't have anything better to suggest. And if we place it entirely under farming, hunting, gymnastic, medicine and cookery rather than statesmanship, we shall be allocating it more correctly. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Of course. **STRANGER:** Well, I think anything pertaining to acquisition, except that of tame animals, has been quite well described under these seven classes. Let's review them. Indeed, it would be most appropriate to place the primeval form at the beginning, after this 'instrument', 'vessel', 'carriage', 'barrier', 'plaything' and 'nourishment'. But if we have omitted anything it can be included in one of these, provided it is something insignificant that has been overlooked, such as the class made up of currency, seals and stamps of all sorts. For these in themselves do not constitute a significant common class. But if some are dragged into the category of adornments, others into that of instruments, they will, despite the force, be entirely concordant therewith. Then everything concerned with the acquisition of tame animals, with the exception of slaves, turns out to have been encompassed by the herd-nurturing skill that we divided into parts earlier. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Entirely so. **STRANGER:** What remains are all slaves and underlings, among whom, I somehow anticipate, those who dispute with the king over the woven web itself will become evident, just as earlier those concerned with spinning and carding, and all the others we mentioned, disputed with the weavers. But all the others,	

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the contributory causes as we called them, have been disposed of along with the works we listed just now, and they have been separated off from the activity of kingship and statesmanship. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** So they seem, anyway. **STRANGER:** Come on, let's consider those who remain by getting closer to them, so that we may recognise them with more certainty. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** That's what's needed. **STRANGER:** Then, from this perspective, we shall find the greatest servants possessing the opposite habit and character to those we anticipated.	

289e–290e — Servants; heralds; diviners and priests; the Egyptian king-priest (290c–e)

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[289e–290e] **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Who are they? **STRANGER:** Those who are bought, and constitute acquisitions in this sense, whom we may indisputably refer to as slaves, and who have the least pretensions to the kingly skill. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Of course. **STRANGER:** But what about those who are free, but willingly assign themselves in servitude to the people we just mentioned by conveying the works of agriculture and the other skills to one another and distributing them out, some resorting to the marketplace, others travelling from city to city by sea and by land, exchanging money for goods and money for money, to whom we have given the name of money-changers, merchants, ship owners and retailers? Surely they will not lay any claim to statesmanship? **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Except, perhaps, insofar as it relates to trading. **STRANGER:** But surely those whom we see so readily serving anyone at all, as hired labourers for payment, would never be found laying claim to kingship. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** No, how could they? **STRANGER:** But what about those who provide services of a different sort? **YOUNG SOCRATES:** What services do you mean, and to whom are you referring? **STRANGER:** The people involved in communications, and those who become wise in written matters through their constant service, and some others who are well able to work out numerous other issues relating to public offices. What shall	Slaves, traders, heralds and clerks are set aside as servants. The herald returns — Mac's figure from 260c–e — again placed below the king because he passes on another's word. Priests and prophets are called a 'servile skill': they carry gifts to the gods and messages from them. This is the heart of Mac's frame: read against Christ's threefold office of priest, prophet and king, the three are not ranked as master and servant but united in one Person. And the baptized share all three: "you are a chosen generation, a kingly priesthood, a holy nation" (1 Peter 2:9). In Egypt the king must be a priest, and at Athens the 'king' chosen by lot performs the old sacrifices. Plato records this union without being able to account for it. Scripture shows the same hint in Melchisedech, "the king of Salem, bringing forth bread and wine, for he was the priest of the most high God" (Genesis 14:18) — a figure the Church reads as pointing to Christ.

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we call these people? **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Servants, as you explained just now. But they are not the people who rule in our cities. **STRANGER:** But I don't think, anyway, that I was in a dream when I said that those who assert the strongest claim to statesmanship would somehow make their appearance in this. And yet, it does seem most unusual to look for them in some subdivision of servitude. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Quite so. **STRANGER:** Then let's get into closer contact with those who have not yet been scrutinised. There are people who possess a portion of some serviceable knowledge of prophecy. Indeed, they are somehow regarded as interpreting from the gods to humanity. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Yes. **STRANGER:** And there is also the class of priests, which, according to tradition, is knowledgeable in bestowing gifts from us upon the gods through sacrifices that are acceptable to them, and also in requesting from them the acquisition of good things for us through prayers. But both of these are part of a servile skill. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** So it appears anyway. **STRANGER:** Well, at this stage we seem to me to have encountered a sort of footprint of the person we are pursuing. For the personage associated with priests and prophets is well stocked with exalted notions, and acquires a reputation for sanctity because of the importance of what he engages in, so that, in Egypt, the king is not permitted to rule without being a priest. And if even he attains the role in the first place by forcing his way in from some other class, it is still necessary for him to be initiated later on into the priestly class. And even among the Greeks, one would find that the performance of the most important sacrifices of this kind are assigned to the most important office holders. And, indeed, what I am saying is no less evident among yourselves here, for it is said that the performance of the most solemn and most traditional of the ancient sacrifices is allocated to the king, whom you choose by lot.	

290e–292a — Centaurs and satyrs; constitutions by rich/poor, force/consent, law/lawlessness

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[291a–292a] **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Entirely so. **STRANGER:** Then we should investigate these kings chosen by lot, who are also	The Stranger sees a shape-shifting chorus — lions, centaurs, satyrs — crowding round public affairs: the sophist-politicians who imitate the statesman. It is comic as much

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priests, and their servants, and another extensive crowd of people who have become evident to us, now that the previous candidates have been set aside. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** What people are you referring to? **STRANGER:** Some very unusual people indeed. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Why so? **STRANGER:** They appear, as I now see it, to belong to an extremely varied class. For many of these men resemble lions, centaurs and other such creatures; very many more are like satyrs, and those weak creatures that adopt many guises, and they rapidly assume each other's characteristics and ability. And, indeed, Socrates, I think I have just appreciated who these men are. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Please tell us, for you seem to have discerned something unusual. **STRANGER:** Yes, for in all cases the unusual is a consequence of ignorance. Indeed, I also experienced this myself just now. I was suddenly thrown into doubt when I beheld the chorus concerned with the affairs of our cities. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** What did you see? **STRANGER:** The greatest beguiler among all the sophists and the person most experienced in this skill – someone who, despite the extreme difficulty of doing so, must be separated from those who really are statesmen and kings, if we are going to catch clear sight of what we are looking for. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Then we really must not relent in this. **STRANGER:** Certainly not. Not in my view, anyway. So tell me this. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** What? **STRANGER:** Isn't monarchy, for us, one of the modes of civic rule? **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Yes. **STRANGER:** I think someone might propose that the exercise of power by a few people comes after monarchy. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Of course. **STRANGER:** And isn't the third form of constitution the rule of the multitude, referred to by the name 'democracy'? **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Entirely so. **STRANGER:** And being three, don't they in some sense become five, engendering two other names from themselves in addition to their own?	as grim; the Stranger is amused at his own surprise. No doom is needed here. Mac sympathises with Benedict-style localism — building sound small communities — but rejects defeatism. Bad imitators of rule have always existed, and the Christian answer is the exiles′ charge: ″seek the peace of the city … and pray to the Lord for it: for in the peace thereof shall be your peace″ (Jeremiah 29:7). The usual sorting of constitutions — one, few, many; rich and poor; force and consent; law and lawlessness — is set out so that it can be questioned. Plato is preparing to say that none of these outward marks is the real test.

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YOUNG SOCRATES: What are they? **STRANGER:** Nowadays, people focus upon the degree of compulsion and willingness, poverty and wealth, law and lawlessness arising in these. And dividing each of them into two, they refer to monarchy by two names on the basis that it constitutes two forms, the tyrannical and the kingly. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Of course. **STRANGER:** And whenever the city is under the power of the few, it is called aristocratic or oligarchic. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Entirely so. **STRANGER:** And yet, in the case of democracy, whether the multitude rules over the possessors of wealth by force or with their consent, or whether they pay close attention to the laws or not, it is not the usual practice for anyone to change its name. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** True. **STRANGER:** What now? Do we think that any of these constitutions is the right one, when it is	

292a–293c — Knowledge the only criterion; few have it; the doctor analogy

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[292b–293b] defined based on these distinctions between one, few and multitude, wealth and poverty, compulsion and willingness, and whether it happens to operate under written laws or without such laws? **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Is there any particular reason why not? **STRANGER:** Well, consider it more clearly by following this argument. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Which? **STRANGER:** Shall we stand by what we said at the outset or shall we dispute it? **YOUNG SOCRATES:** What are you referring to? **STRANGER:** We said, I believe, that kingly rule is one of the branches of knowledge. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Yes. **STRANGER:** And it did not belong to all of them. Rather, we preferred one that was judged and one that was directive over the others. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Yes.	The only true test of right rule is knowledge, and very few can have it — fewer than the good draughts players in a thousand men. A Catholic reader can agree that rule is a matter of wisdom, not numbers, while remembering that true wisdom begins in the fear of the Lord. The doctor analogy: a physician is a physician whether he cures us willingly or not, with or without written rules. This is the tension flagged at 276d–e. It holds only if the ruler's command truly rests on truth and aims at our good. Where it does not, the prophet's word judges the king: "We ought to obey God, rather than men" (Acts 5:29). Plato has no figure who both knows perfectly and can be trusted perfectly with power. The Christian answer is not a better philosopher-king but the King who gave his life for the sheep — the good shepherd with whom this section of the dialogue began.

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STRANGER: And from the directive category we selected one that applied to inanimate products, and another that applied to living beings. And so, making divisions in this manner, we have been continually approaching this point where, without losing sight of knowledge, we are as yet unable to adequately describe precisely what the knowledge is. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** What you are saying is correct. **STRANGER:** So, do we appreciate this particular point, that the definition of these constitutions involves neither few nor many, willingness nor unwillingness, neither poverty nor wealth? Rather, if we are to be guided by our previous discussion, it involves some type of knowledge. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** But of course. It is impossible to conclude otherwise. **STRANGER:** Then, it is now necessary to consider this issue in this way. In which of these constitutions, if any, does it turn out that knowledge of the rule of humanity, perhaps the most important knowledge and the most difficult to acquire, arises? For we need to see this so that we may behold certain people who must be separated from the sagacious king, people who pretend to be statesmen and who persuade many others of this, but are not statesmen at all. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Yes, that's what must be done, since our argument has said so. **STRANGER:** Now, do you think that a large number of people in the city are able to acquire this knowledge? **YOUNG SOCRATES:** No, how could they? **STRANGER:** Well, in a city of a thousand men, could some hundred, or even fifty, acquire it in an adequate manner? **YOUNG SOCRATES:** On that basis anyway it would be the easiest skill of them all. Indeed, we know that among a thousand men you wouldn't even find that number of first-class draughts players, in relation to the other Greek cities, let alone kings. For based upon the previous argument, it is surely necessary for someone who possesses knowledge of kingship to be referred to as kingly anyway, whether he exercises rule or not. **STRANGER:** You have remembered that very well. And following on from this, it is necessary, I believe, to look for right rule associated with one particular person, or two, or extremely few, whenever such rule arises. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Why, of course.	

Horan translation	Notes
STRANGER: Yes. But these people, whether they rule over consenting or unconsenting subjects, whether on the basis of written laws or without written laws, whether they themselves be wealthy or poor, must be regarded as exercising whatever rule they exercise on the basis of a skill according to our present view. And we do not regard physicians as less than physicians whether they cure us with our consent or without it, whether by cutting, burning or applying some other painful cure, whether they work from written guidelines or without [293b–293c] them, whether they are poor or wealthy. In all these cases we declare that they are physicians nonetheless, as long as their directions are based upon a skill. This may involve purifying, or otherwise reducing, or even adding bulk to the body, but once these are directed to some good of our bodies, making them better when they were worse, the individual practitioners preserve the lives of the people they treat. On such a basis I believe, and on no other, shall we propose that this alone is the correct definition of the rule of medicine, and of any other rule whatsoever. **YOUNG SOCRATES:** Exactly.	